

Unit 3: Healthy Love, Relationships, and Intimacy

In this unit, the group will explore next steps for breaking cycles of abuse and violence, from learning the consequences of abuse and learning about ways to be accountable for our actions, to assessing empathy as an important relationship tool. The unit seeks to answer the following thematic questions:

- How can I identify healthy patterns, feelings, and behaviors in my personal relationships?
- How can I identify abusive dynamics in my personal relationships?
- What is the difference between sympathy and empathy? Why and how is empathy important?
- How do we get our needs met without using abusive behavior?

Lesson 1: Abuse and Its Outcomes

Icebreaker

Choose an icebreaker from the Icebreaker List.

Lesson Script

So far in our group, we've discussed abuse, culture, and gender. But even with all that we've learned so far, we haven't yet spent time examining the outcomes and consequences of abuse. Why does abusive behavior matter? What happens in people's minds and bodies when they are abused or abusing?

Statistics estimate that 45% of men and 49% of women have experienced some form of psychological aggression from a partner (CDC, [National Intimate Partner and Sexual Violence Survey](#), 2016/2017). There aren't reliable statistics yet for non-binary folks, but statistics from the queer community more broadly suggest equal or higher instances of physical and emotional violence. The emotional and psychological impacts of all of this violence is staggering. There are direct links between experiencing domestic violence and depression, anxiety, post-traumatic stress disorder, and substance abuse.

All the fear and insecurity that people attempt to alleviate through abusive behavior is instead reinforced by it. The more power and control we seek through other people, the more we struggle internally. Issues with anger, self-control, anxiety, and intimacy are all magnified by being abusive to a partner or relative.

Episodes of violence can escalate over time until legal and health issues are unbearable. The statistics on intimate partner violence leading to homicide tell us that death is a regular outcome of abuse, especially for women, and even more so for women experiencing marginalization: women of color, women with disabilities, and women on government assistance.

It is crucial to weigh these consequences of abuse in your life, and determine if they are consequences you are willing to suffer or have your loved ones suffer. And if they are not, you will need to develop a safe plan for exiting an abusive situation or relationship. Today, we'll be thinking about how to make a plan to de-escalate your abuse and/or safely remove yourself from a violent situation.

Handout 6: Safety Planning

Whether you're planning for your own safety or that of a partner or family member, coming up with a safety plan is a vital practice if you're involved in domestic violence. Often, getting out of a situation where you are being abused and/or abusing someone else is not as simple as just picking up and leaving. Emotional ties, and logistics around money, children, transportation, and safe shelter all come up for someone thinking about leaving an abusive home or relationship. Fear of retaliation is also a consideration, so leaving home often needs to be well thought-out and executed quickly. Let's take a look at a handout that will help us with our safety planning strategies. Take some time to fill it out, and then we'll discuss as a group.

Large Group Discussion

- Does having a safety plan make you feel more secure?
- How did it feel to make a plan?
- Why do you think it can be hard to leave abusive situations?
- What do you think about the mental health outcomes of abuse?
- Do you have any questions about safety and resources?
- Do you have any questions about outcomes of abuse?

Lesson 2: Identifying Healthy Patterns

Icebreaker

Choose an icebreaker from the Icebreaker List.

Lesson Script

We've spent a lot of time discussing patterns of violence, power, and abuse—that's because part of figuring out what's healthy is knowing what's toxic. Today's session moves us in a different direction, and helps us identify and maintain positive, healthy cycles and patterns.

In order to participate in healthy relationships, we have to know what motivates and strengthens us. As with most things in this group, it comes back to power and control. In abuse, placing power and control in someone else's hands—someone being abusive or someone we feel the need to control—leads to dissatisfaction, violence, and anger. Learning what makes you feel powerful from within is key. Learning self-control is a fundamental way we develop healthier patterns free from abuse.

Take a moment to answer the reflection questions on Handout 7 about when you feel most and least powerful and in control. There are no right answers; we will work on processing the answers together.

Handout 7: Healthy Patterns

Partner Sharing

With a partner, I want you to take turns sharing your answers to these questions. As you listen to your partner, make note of when your partner mentions other people among the things that make them feel empowered, powerless, anxious, and in control.

Large Group

- *What did you notice about this activity?*
- *Was there anything your partner said that inspired you?*
- *How many of the things that empowered you have to do with other people?*

- *How many of the things that made you feel anxious and out of control have to do with other people?*
- *Are there times you feel empowered on your own?*
- *Give me some examples of the things you found empowering.*
- *Give me some examples of the things you found anxiety-producing.*
- *Are there any questions about thinking of power and control in healthy ways?*

Lesson 3: Accountability and Empathy

Icebreaker

Choose an icebreaker from the Icebreaker List.

Lesson Script

Today, we're thinking about accountability and empathy in the context of abuse. It is important that we know that someone being abused is not at fault for their abuse. We are only accountable for our own behavior. You cannot take blame for others. But knowing when to take accountability for your own actions is a challenge that requires skill, practice, and perspective. In order to assess our skills in taking accountability, we're going to do an activity that will give us some practice in reframing blaming statements.

Activity

Before the session begins, gather a bowl, writing utensil, and paper. On small strips of paper, write the following phrases, fold them, and place them in the bowl:

- She picks/starts the fights.
- It's not my fault.
- If he just listened to me, we could have avoided a fight.
- She makes me do that.
- I can't help it.
- They provoke me.
- Things are tense because of her.
- He ruins everything.

Have the members of the group move around the circle and select one of the phrases from the bowl. One at a time, discuss ways you can reframe those statements from blaming statements to statements which take accountability.

Lesson Script (continued)

One strategy for thinking about how you can be accountable is to think about how the person you're engaging with thinks and feels. Trying to put yourself in another person's shoes is difficult, and requires empathy.

What does empathy mean?

- **Empathy** is being able to feel the feelings of another person, being able to meaningfully see from their vantage point.

What's the difference between sympathy and empathy?

- **Sympathy** is feeling sorry for the suffering or negative emotions and experiences of others. Where empathy asks you to feel what they feel, sympathy is more removed.

Large Group Discussion

- When can empathy be a detriment? For yourself? Others?
- What happens when we refuse to take accountability?
- What happens when we assume accountability for things we don't have control over?
- Are there any questions about abuse and accountability, or about empathy?